

available for download. The app can do a more thorough inspection and gives you direct links to update old and programs that are potentially not secure.

Avoid shady web sites:

You should avoid web sites that offer serial numbers, key generators, cracks and other below-the-line content. These websites are crawling with malware just waiting to infect your system. In general, as a thumb rule be careful where you surf. In order to make sure that you accidentally don't end up stumbling on to such a web site, you should install plug-ins/addons such as LinkExtend and McAfee Site Advisor. These plug-ins give you a security rating of any link in searches. Use an ad blocking plugin such as Adblock Plus or a site filter list (urlfilter.ini for Opera). Download free software only from sites you know and trust. Attractive looking free software downloads frequently bundle other software, including spyware, adware, trojans and other junk. Besides this, here are a few DONTs:

- Don't click on links inside pop-ups.
- Don't click on links in spam or popups that claim to offer anti-spyware software; you may unintentionally be installing spyware. And please don't fall for web pages that open small dialog boxes designed to look like system messages.

Switch to non standard applications:

Non standard applications are generally more secure and less prone to attacks. Part of the reason is that malware makers don't think it's worthwhile to make attack codes for them as against popular software. You could try using Firefox as against IE, or Foxit instead of Adobe reader. Besides, non standard applications are quite light on resources.

Use signature scanning services:

As a rule, one should only install applications that have

come from a trusted source. If you come across an application that you're not quite sure of, you can verify its signature from online services such as <http://virusscan.jotti.org/en> or <http://www.virustotal.com/>

Run high risk programs in a virtual machine:

If you absolutely must run an application that could be potentially dangerous, try running it in a virtual machine. This is a form of virtualisation wherein a virtual hardware platform is created on top of a software layer that keeps it separated from your underlying OS. This way if a virus infects your VM, your underlying OS remains safe. Vmware and Virtual Box are popular virtualisation solutions.

Internal tweaking

Enabling or disabling certain Windows features can also strengthen the security of your PC. Here are some common techniques.

Use a limited user account

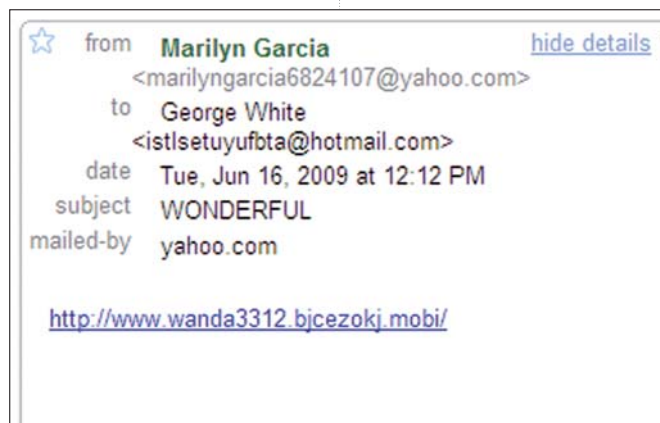


Vista running in virtual box

and therefore, restricts even what malware can do. However, the downside is that it is slightly inconvenient to use. To set up a limited user account go the Control Panel, select User Accounts and create a new user account as a limited user.

Disable file sharing

If you're using Windows XP SP 2, click **Start > Control Panel**. Click **Security Center > Windows**



Example of a spurious spam mail with a suspicious link

Most viruses that get installed under an admin account have access to enable/disable many internal configuration settings. For example, if you accidentally download a virus while you are logged in through the admin account (that has full rights enabled), the virus can disable AV and firewall on its own. To avoid this kind of a complication, you should do your day to day work from a limited user account. This type of a user account has limited privileges,

Firewall. Click the Exceptions tab. Under **Programs and Services**, uncheck the box next to **File and Printer Sharing**. Click **OK**. This will disable your files from being shared over any network.

Use common sense

Differentiate between icons. For instance a new folder and New Folder.exe. Some viruses make an EXE file with the name of the most frequently clicked folder on a USB drive.



HOSTS file tweaking

A HOST file contains the IP addresses to hosts on the internet. By redirecting them back to your own home IP (127.0.0.1) you can effectively block out ad servers, cookies, and bugs. The names of most known offenders are known. Fortunately you don't have to know the name of each and every one since ready made hosts files are available online. All you need to do is download such a HOSTS file and replace it with you existing one. The default location for the hosts file is as follows. Be sure to save a copy of the original if you wish to revert back:
Windows Vista = C:\WINDOWS\SYSTEM32\DRIVERS\ETC
Windows XP = C:\WINDOWS\SYSTEM32\DRIVERS\ETC

You should be able to spot such a file on account of the extension.

Avoid clicking links in emails that look suspicious or on the internet

Online virus scans

Trend Micro Housecall
(<http://housecall.trendmicro.com>)

Bitdefender Online Scanner
(<http://www.bitdefender.com/scanner/online/free.html>)

Kaspersky Online Scanner
(<http://www.kaspersky.com/virusscanner>)

ESET Online Scanner
(<http://www.eset.com/onlinescan/>)